a growing realisation in the rank and file of the BJP and RSS that discarding the Jan Sangh in 1980 was a folly. While the ideological spread of the Jan Sangh has remained intact, the credibility of the BJP is going down … It is necessary that nationalist forces should come together. This demands the return of the BJP and the reunification of the Bharatiya Jan Sangh under the saffron flag.

Essentially, he was saying that the BJP won when it was unambiguous about its first principles and declined when it diluted them to focus on wider issues. As one long-standing UP MLA asked me: 'Why does Yogi Adityanath have such support?' His answer:[23]

Does he meet people well? Do people know him as a polite person? No. The reason is basically mukhar [in your face] and ugra [aggressive] Hindutva. This is why BJP is rising. In elections, Yogi is in demand as a campaigner in each state, the most after Narendra Modi and Amit Shah. Why? Because of Hindutva. We are seeing an awakening of Hindutva, it is a punarjaagaran [reawakening]. Those who espoused Hinduism earlier were put aside. Do you think Muslims are with SP because of its idea of Samajwaad [socialism] or Ram Manohar Lohia's ideology or socialism or because of a community mobilisation? Now that is different with Hindus too, to some extent.

An illustration of this is Yogi Adityanath's decision to end the tradition of iftar parties to mark Ramzan in Lucknow, just as Modi ended it in Delhi. He even declared on the floor of the UP assembly that, as a proud Hindu, he saw no reason for him to celebrate Eid. Yogi said that he was not one of those people who wear 'janeu' (sacred thread) inside the house and don skull caps outside when needed. 'I am not like them because I am a Hindu and have no reason to celebrate Eid,' he said. He added, however, that his government would 'continue to work for a peaceful Eid'.[24] This is why Yogi Adityanath's government, soon after coming to power, also doubled the grants for Hindu pilgrims undertaking holy visits to the Kailash Mansarovar from ₹50,000 to ₹1 lakh each.[25] This was